

MY400/MY500/MY4IR – Fundamentals of Social Research Design

2025/26

Practice paper 3 – to prepare for in-class test

On the following pages you will find three short (one-page) descriptions of research projects. Please choose ONE of them, and answer the following questions in relation to that project description.

Please indicate clearly at the top of your answer booklet which project (A, B or C) you are referring to.

1. Describe the nature of the research design, using TWO of the frameworks that we have referred to in the course (e.g. fixed/flexible; inductive/deductive/etc; variance-oriented/process-oriented), explaining why you identify it that way.
2. Comment critically on the research questions. How could they be improved?
3. Comment on the alignment between the different elements of the project. For example, how well does the proposed data collection or analysis 'fit' with the research questions? What changes, if any, would you propose to improve the research design? (You can be as imaginative as you like here.)
4. Comment on any particular strengths or limitations of the project, as it is described.

Project A – Shared Causes, Different Contexts: How Student Activists Understand Cross-Border Collaboration

Introduction

Student activism increasingly involves links to groups abroad, through shared campaign materials and online coordination. This project explored student activists interpret these international connections and how they view the relationship between global and campus-level activism.

The study is informed by transnationalism and social movement theory, which emphasise how actors mobilise across borders and how shared identities and networks shape participation and strategy. Understanding the subjective interpretations of student activists can reveal how global norms, symbols, and practices are adapted locally, and how actors perceive the effectiveness of wider movements.

Research Questions

1. How do student activists describe their engagement with international networks?
2. What influence does cross-border collaboration have on the global effectiveness of youth movements?
3. To what extent do participants' accounts indicate general principles of transnational movement-building?

Research Design

Twelve leaders of activist student societies were purposively sampled from four UK universities. The societies selected were those whose names included "*activist*", "*advocate*", or similar in their society name. The four universities were selected to cover a range of campus sizes and disciplinary focuses. In semi-structured interviews (25–40 minutes), participants were asked to reflect on their international contacts, shared resources, and involvement in global campaigns. They were also asked about the perceived global effectiveness of youth movements in general. Interviews were conducted over a three-month period in person or via video call, and all were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim. Transcripts were thematically coded, comparing recurring ideas across universities, with a focus on patterns in framing, strategies, and perceived constraints.

Findings

Participants described international links as both inspiring and logistically challenging. Some emphasised solidarity with partners abroad, while others stressed uneven communication. Several believed that international visibility strengthened their campaigns, although specific examples were not detailed. A tentative outline of "student transnationalism" is proposed, emphasising shared symbols, learning, and fluctuating commitment levels.

Ethics

Participants gave informed consent by signing a consent form, having been sent an information sheet in advance. Interviews avoided potentially sensitive information about internal disagreements within student societies. Audio files were stored on an encrypted device, and anonymised summaries were shared with respondents.

Project B – Parallel Responses: A Comparative Study of How Two Small States Manage Foreign Policy Crises

Introduction

Small states often face diplomatic pressures during international crises, yet the internal processes shaping their responses are not well understood. This project compared how the foreign ministries of Ireland and Singapore organised internal decision-making during recent foreign policy challenges.

The research draws on small state theory and bureaucratic politics frameworks, highlighting how structural constraints, institutional hierarchies, and decision-making routines shape responses to external pressures. By exploring officials' reflections, the study seeks to illuminate the interaction between institutional design, leadership practices, and contextual pressures in shaping foreign policy outcomes.

Research Questions

1. How do small states manage internal processes during foreign policy crises?
2. What similarities and differences emerge between Ireland and Singapore in terms of coordination, leadership, and information management?
3. To what extent can the findings support broader interpretations of small state crisis diplomacy?

Research Design

A small-N comparative case design was used. Four interviews were conducted in each country (n = 8 total) with current or recently retired foreign ministry officials. Interviews (30–45 minutes) explored internal coordination, decision roles, and perceived constraints.

The cases were selected because both countries had experienced notable foreign policy crises in the last three years: Ireland with Brexit-related diplomatic negotiations and Singapore with regional trade tensions in the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN).

Interviews were conducted over a six-week period and transcribed for thematic analysis. The comparison followed a thematic framework, though some topics were covered more extensively in certain interviews than others. Contrasts between countries are primarily drawn from officials' reflections on how decisions unfolded, with attention to decision processes, communication patterns, and perceived pressures.

Findings

Officials in Ireland emphasised consensus-driven decision-making, whereas Singapore officials highlighted hierarchical coordination and reliance on a core advisory circle. Both groups noted time pressure and incomplete information as key challenges. The study suggests preliminary differences between "consensus-oriented" and "hierarchical" crisis-response styles, although these may partly reflect the specific context of the crises rather than underlying institutional features.

Ethics

Participants provided informed consent by signing a consent form, having been provided with an

information sheet. Interviews avoided classified material. Audio files were securely stored, and only thematic summaries were shared in the report. Pseudonyms and paraphrasing were used in the thematic summaries in order to avoid reporting sensitive information.

Project C – Logging Off to Engage: A Causal Study of Digital Wellbeing Practices in Contemporary Offices

Introduction

Digital-wellbeing initiatives, such as no-email evenings or designated focus hours, are increasingly used to mitigate workplace stress. This project sought to estimate the causal impact of these initiatives on employee stress levels, combining survey and administrative communication data.

The study is framed within workplace stress theory and behavioural intervention frameworks, which suggest that individual behaviour and organisational practices interact to influence wellbeing outcomes. By examining differential participation and organisational context, the study seeks to understand both the direct impact of initiatives and the potential moderating role of team culture and workload patterns.

Research Questions

1. Do digital-wellbeing initiatives reduce employee stress levels?
2. How does the intensity of participation in digital wellbeing practices (e.g., compliance with keeping certain times free of email) affect stress outcomes?
3. Are observed effects robust to differences in seniority, workload, or team culture?

Research Design

A quasi-experimental design was employed. Two large organisations implementing digital-wellbeing initiatives in some of their departments were studied over a 12-week period, with a total sample of 175 employees across the organisations. Weekly surveys collected self-reported stress scores (0–10 scale) before and after implementation. Administrative records of email activity and calendar scheduling were used as proxies for digital engagement and participation in digital wellbeing practices.

A difference-in-differences approach compared employees in departments using digital-wellbeing initiatives to those in the same organisation who did not, controlling for seniority of role and workload. Random assignment to conditions was not possible due to a range of practical constraints. Analyses explored both short-term and cumulative effects on stress, and variation across teams was examined to identify potential moderating factors.

Findings

Employees participating in digital wellbeing initiatives reported a modest reduction in stress relative to non-participants. Greater compliance with digital wellbeing practices was associated with larger stress reductions. Some variation appeared linked to team culture, suggesting that organisational context may moderate the effects of the initiatives.

Ethics

Employees provided informed consent. Administrative email data were anonymised and analysed in aggregate. Participants were informed that the study aimed to evaluate wellbeing initiatives without disclosing individual stress scores to management.